



EXPERIENCING FILM TOURISM

Authenticity & Fellowship

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Abstract: Authenticity, existential authenticity, sincerity, hyperreality and simulacra are overlapping concepts often used in accounting for the tourist experience. This study discusses these concepts in the context of a case study of *Lord of the Rings* film-induced tourism to New Zealand. Findings support an elaborated and extended version of authenticity that incorporates aspects of object and existential authenticity, sincerity of relationships and embodied experiences of place. These factors underpin tourists' judgments and experiences of authenticity. Links are drawn between this analysis and the theoplacity framework for religious pilgrimage. It is concluded that value emanates not only from objects or sights but also from the moments of embodied interaction with place and others, which actively constitute those objects and sights. **Keywords:** film tourism, authenticity, sincerity, existential authenticity, tourist experience. Crown Copyright © 2009 Published by Elsevier Ltd. All rights reserved.

INTRODUCTION

An understandable preoccupation of tourism research has been the question of how best to characterise tourists' experiences as they travel and encounter places, people, environments and cultures. This has proved to be no easy task. Even the, apparently, simplest of such experiences can, when under close scrutiny, expand into complexity and defy ready explanation. When faced with such complexity, one strategy is to focus on explaining particular, clearly specified, aspects of the simplest cases available in the hope of achieving incremental progress. An alternative strategy is to seek out examples at the extremes—much like a medical researcher who might focus on a rare, possibly spectacular, pathology in order to shed light on a commoner, related disease or disorder.

In this paper we report a study of an especially complex form of tourist experience—a particular example of film-induced tourism. We do so in order to advance understanding of tourist experiences in general.

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In particular, we attempt to incorporate, integrate and theoretically deepen and extend research on a number of established concepts in the tourism literature, such as ‘authenticity’, ‘existential authenticity’, ‘sincerity’, ‘simulacra’ and ‘hyperreality’. In this attempt, we highlight tourist interactions with place, others and their own embodied experiences of these. We suggest that tourist experiences—and the extent to which tourists might find them to be authentic—are often constituted by a ‘collusion’ between ‘objects’, places, others and a tourist’s embodied interaction with these.

Notions of Authenticity

Ever since MacCannell (1973, 1976) popularised the notion of ‘authenticity’ as a putative motive for tourist activity and experience, controversy over the usefulness of the term has continued. Some have seen nothing but problems with the concept and have argued for its limited utility (e.g., Cohen, 1988), the need to modify it or substitute it with other terms (e.g., Taylor’s (2001) argument in favour of the idea of ‘sincerity’) or its complete abandonment (e.g., Bruner, 1994). Similarly, Reisinger and Steiner (2006) have argued that scholars should abandon both the concept and term ‘object authenticity’ and recommended the use of the term existential authenticity instead. Belhassen and Caton (2006, p. 845) countered with the suggestion that, conversely, such open concepts could “be seen as highly functional, rather than counterproductive, since they serve as flashpoints around which scholars working from different perspectives can congregate, debate, deliberate, and influence one another, thereby allowing new and more informed understandings to emerge”.

Further, while Reisinger and Steiner (2006) seem intent on persuading ‘scholars’ to abandon judgments of object authenticity it remains the case that tourists continue to make such judgments. Rather than being Heideggerian phenomenologists encountering, simply, ‘what is’ they are often as concerned in establishing or ‘negotiating’ the ‘objectively’ authentic status of objects and activities as are ‘scholars’. In addition the common use of the notion of authenticity in the travel industry and by tourists themselves suggests its relevance for researchers if only in the sense that such usage is itself a phenomenon of interest. Nevertheless, Steiner and Reisinger (2006b, p. 857) were understandably concerned at the lack of “solidarity, unity, and consensus” over the meaning of object authenticity and that consequently the discourse would not be fruitful for theorising.

Looming in the background of this discussion of authenticity in tourism is a broader debate or discussion over the usefulness of what is most often termed a ‘postmodern’ analysis of tourism (e.g., MacCannell, 1992; Rojek, 1993; Uriely, 2005; Urry, 1990, 2002). The discussion over the merits of postmodern interpretations of contemporary society continues to reverberate throughout the social sciences and related studies. More relevantly, Uriely (2005) has noted how research on the tourist experience has been influenced by the ‘commitments’ of

postmodern scholarship (e.g., the de-differentiation of tourism from everyday life, pluralized depictions of tourists, a focus on negotiated and subjective meanings). He has discerned an intellectual shift in the tourism literature that reveals theorizing about tourists is itself a product of its time.

We will only focus here, however, on the introduction of two key terms from this postmodern literature into tourism studies—‘hyperreality’ and ‘simulacra’. Following on from Boorstin’s (1964) notion of the ‘pseudo-event’, Eco (1983) introduced the term ‘hyperreality’. Principally, he examined American society which he interpreted as historically depthless yet seemed, paradoxically, to be fascinated with garish reproductions of places and events from other times and places. In their commodified forms these reproductions were touted as ‘bigger’ and ‘better’ than the originals. However, he also noted that this tendency was not uniform, and those areas of the United States that could boast more substantial history of their own tended to avoid the more extreme instances of this ‘hyperreality’. Hyperreality, then, emerges within the context of an ahistorical, consumerist society and involves a strong focus on the spectacular and ‘non-ordinary’. Travel and tourism are prime sites for its production. As places become ‘attractions’, as historical events become today’s tourist ‘experiences’, and as every facet of the real is reconfigured for the ‘tourist gaze’ reality becomes one with hyperreality—at least for the tourist.

It is a relatively straightforward step to see the connections between the notion of hyperreality and that of ‘simulacra’ (Baudrillard, 1983). In a world of layered reproduction (i.e., layers of ‘copies’) the idea of the original loses its privileged place, or any place at all. The so-called original itself becomes understood as yet another ‘sign’, constantly reproduced in its own image. Reality retreats to be replaced by simulacra that comprise a world of signification rather than one of objects and events (also compare Pretes, 1995). In this broader theoretical context, the notion of the authentic is clearly problematic. Bruner (1994) proposed, from a social constructionist perspective, that authenticity should be dumped from the tourism literature. In a sophisticated criticism of the work of Eco and Baudrillard, he argued that implicit in these so-called ‘postmodern’ perspectives is, in fact, a lurking realism. As Europeans, Bruner (1994) claimed, Eco and Baudrillard were privileging the presumed ‘original’ (and hence ‘real’ or ‘authentic’) European versions of American reproductions. To put his point simply, if reality is *all* simulacra, *all* hyperreality then, in a surprisingly paradoxical outcome, it could only be an arrogant superiority that led one to speak of *hyperreality* at all.

Despite this wider consideration of the postmodern in tourism and despite specific criticisms of the usefulness of the notion of authenticity, other researchers, as mentioned, have sought to maintain a place for ‘authenticity’ in understanding the tourist experience (Li, 2000; May, 1996; Reisinger & Steiner, 2006; Selwyn, 1996; Steiner & Reisinger 2006a; Wang, 1999, 2007). These authors qualify and elaborate upon the basic idea of ‘authenticity’ in the tourist experience by arguing that its subjective or constructed nature does not necessarily disqualify it as

a theoretically enlightening construct but simply makes the need for increasingly sophisticated understandings of authenticity more urgent. When combined with the continuing employment by tourists of notions centred on the concept of authenticity (as was the case in the study that forms the basis of this article), this thread of theorising cautions against complete abandonment of the idea. Indeed, Reisinger and Steiner argue for the conceptual usefulness of notions centred on existential authenticity for tourism researchers despite having advocated for the abandonment of object authenticity for those same scholars (Reisinger & Steiner, 2006; Steiner & Reisinger, 2006a).

Wang (1999), for example, has argued for distinguishing what he terms ‘existential authenticity’. This amounts to an alternative rendering of authenticity which depends neither upon some assumed absolutist, object-oriented and objectively established criteria of ‘authenticity’ nor upon an irredeemably subjective, relativistic and entirely constructed understanding of authenticity. As Wang (1999) explains:

Existential authenticity, unlike [the] object-related version, can often have nothing to do with the issue of whether toured objects are real. In search of [a] tourist experience which is existentially authentic, tourists are preoccupied with an existential state of Being activated by certain tourist activities (Wang, 1999, p. 359).

Existential authenticity, understood in this activity based way, seems particularly well-suited to understanding evolving tourist experiences (compare Steiner & Reisinger, 2006a) and as it will be argued might be especially relevant in explaining the film tourism experience and, conversely, using the film tourism experience to gain a deeper understanding of existential authenticity. As Kim and Jamal (2007) found in their examination of the experience of participants of the Texas Renaissance Festival:

The notion of existential authenticity is central to understanding the experience of regular, repeat festivalgoers who take their participation seriously. This committed action is a means of attaining heightened bodily feelings, expressing, regaining, or reconstructing a sense of desired self, and developing authentic intersubjective relationships (Kim & Jamal, 2007, p. 181).

The study showed that the “ritualistic participation in this medieval themed festival may be understood as a quest for authentic self and human relationships via a socially constructed alternative reality” (Kim & Jamal, 2007, p. 198) and that highly committed tourists can gain ‘self’ authenticity even at a commercial tourism event. However, Belhassen, Caton, and Stewart (2008) note that the term existential authenticity still “obscures the way that toured sites/objects and social discourses often exist in dialogue with experiences of existential authenticity” (Belhassen et al., 2008, p. 674) and that consequently the setting and collective understanding of place is a part of existential authenticity. They suggest a framework coined ‘theoplicity’ “as an integrative conceptual tool that combines the elements of place, belief, action, and self, which exist in dialogue and which act together to produce

the complex notion of authenticity” (Belhassen et al., 2008, p. 685). Further, these authors argue that such a framework helps to mesh previous understandings of authenticity with broader contexts.

The study and discussion presented here integrates many of the seminal ideas surrounding notions of authenticity and, in addition, adapts and extends the framework presented by considering notions of settings and ideology and their influences on the experience of self and place.

Case Study ‘Lord of the Rings’ Film Tourism

One arena of tourist activity that serves as a robust conceptual and empirical ‘field test’ of Wang’s (1999) existential authenticity and also Belhassen et al.’s (2008) theoplacity framework is film tourism, which this study defines as visitation of a site or a location, that is or has been used for or is associated with filming. Such film tourism immediately provokes a multi-layered questioning of what is meant, by tourists, when they speak of an authentic experience (or use words that connote something similar). Further, films, even documentaries, are understood inherently as representations, simulations and contrivances. They are emblematic of the proliferation of simulacra and the hyperreal. ‘Editorial’ (i.e., direction) control, cinematographic skills and technologies and artistic, entertainment and aesthetic values are all acknowledged to be part of the process of film production (Beeton, 2005). To that extent, there is an apparent, albeit complex, conflict in the relationship between the notion of ‘authentic’ film experiences and this highly artifactual production process.

A second layer of complexity arises once film tourism becomes the focus. Added to a cinematographic experience is ‘real world’ travel to specific destinations which have either been associated with the production of the film or have been depicted in film. Further, some destinations do not represent themselves in film but are a physical substitute for other ‘real’ places. This is not the end of the complexity. Entirely fictional films—inspired as they may have been by real places, personalities and events—raise the question about the ontological status of fictional places and characters and about what ontological commitments are required of readers (or viewers) of fiction. Most intriguingly, how do such ontological commitments impact upon the experience of existential authenticity and especially how does one ‘stay true to one’s real self’ during immersion in fictional worlds?

The study that forms the basis of the following discussion and argument incorporates all these layers of complexity and adds yet another layer (or set of layers) to this conundrum. The *Lord of the Rings* films—produced in New Zealand and which form the basis of significant tourism activity—are particular representations or interpretations of a story that was fictional; further, those representations are, in substantial part, products of advanced computer graphic simulation capabilities. The film script is based on J.R.R. Tolkien’s *The Lord of the Rings* novel that describes the adventures of the hobbit Frodo Baggins and his friends. The novel concerns an entire world, with its own history,

peoples, languages and geography, in which the fellowship have to ensure the destruction of a powerful ring that would otherwise forever see their land enslaved by a dark and twisted lord. Together they travel across Middle-earth and their struggles in challenging environments present an important element of this story of adventure, sacrifice and friendship. Fifty years after their publication the story was interpreted by cinematographer Peter Jackson in three films (2001, 2002, 2003). This film trilogy placed a significant emphasis on the supporting role of landscapes and scenery to illustrate the story's elements and proved hugely successful. Tolkien's 'Middle-earth' excited strong interest, commitment and even devotion from avid 'fans' of his work. These fans are, curiously, especially concerned with 'authentic' depictions that are 'loyal' to the original novel. That loyalty, as will be shown, is not judged by an unthinking literalism but by something deeper or more essential to Tolkien's work.

Given this multi-layered complexity, why is it that film tourists participating, in this case, on multi-day tours of New Zealand/Middle-earth so often resort to simple descriptors that indicate concerns with 'authenticity', 'genuineness' and 'reality'? In this objectively complex and indeterminate geography of the authentic, what do these words—and the experiences they describe—'really' mean? In fact, viewed from the heights of objectivity, one might expect that these sorts of words would be the last ones chosen to describe and ground film tourist experiences associated with the *Lord of the Rings* films. However, the authenticity of the film tourism experience is highly important to the tourists as this in-depth study shows. The basis of this authenticity is akin to Wang's (1999) notion of existential authenticity; and furthermore shaped by the additional dimensions of the setting in which tourists experience this feeling as well as on broader "ideologies which help to construct the setting's meaning, both in advance of and through the process of the tourism encounter" (Belhassen et al., 2008, p. 674). Film tourists, at least in this case, navigate this apparently complex pursuit of the authentic in a way that reveals its anchor in some basic social, moral and spiritual concerns. These concerns are not the fickle products of arbitrary social construction or postmodern simulacra but neither are they easily and objectively articulated. These discourses of authenticity are, in fact, grounded in deeply conventional understandings applied flexibly but coherently to each of the layers of experience discussed. Just as people are at home in the everyday complexity of social interaction so are they, discursively, at home in the complex authenticity of film tourism.

This study enriches the theoretical debate on the concept of authenticity by examining its relevance to the experiences of film tourists. In detail, we seek to synthesize previous approaches to authenticity as well as apply and extend the conceptual framework referred to as 'theoplacity' by Belhassen et al. (2008). Consequently, this study will show that physical places and social settings (the fellowship of the tour group) are pivotal to understanding tourists' sense of what is and is not an authentic experience. In this it will involve returning the 'place'—which includes its meanings as a physical, spatially 'fixed' location

understood in terms of its physical geography—to the tourist experience. Authenticity is dependent on place, even if it is understood as existential authenticity. Furthermore, we are emphasizing the way in which tourists are quite aware of and able to navigate through the layers of their experience of both New Zealand and ‘Middle-Earth’ to make judgments, from setting to setting, about the authenticity of their experiences. They navigate the multi-layered construction of the ‘reality’ they wish to experience—from the fictional books, through the film version of them, the ‘making ofs’ (short documentaries that ‘reveal’ the back stage of those versions), through the mix of New Zealand places, film sets (sometimes no longer existent) and fictional places. Lastly we show the significance of embodiment as we emphasize through the data the very ‘embodied’ way in which physical places are encountered and contribute to authenticity.

Overall, the discussion has the objective of synthesizing previous approaches to authenticity, including ‘hyperreality’ and ‘simulacra’, within the context of a seemingly ‘perfect’ example of multilayered simulation and artifice, and to extend the conceptual framework referred to as ‘theoplicity’ to propose a suitable framework for the study of film tourism.

FILM TOURISM, AUTHENTICITY AND SINCERITY

Study Methods

The study that provides the underpinning data for this argument was part of a qualitative, four year research project into the motivations, expectations and the experiences of film tourists. It concentrated on the analysis of three nationwide tours each of 15 days length. Each tour covered a minimum of 30 locations between Queenstown in the South Island and Auckland in the North Island and took place over the summer periods of 2004/2005 and 2005/2006, and cost around US\$ 3,000 per person (without airfare). The field study of those tours allowed for in-depth examination of selected features regarding the expectations and experience of the film tourists over a duration of time (Neuman, 1997). One of the researchers accompanied the tours NW1 with its 16 participants and NW2 with its 23 participants over their whole duration using pre- and post-tour questionnaires, individual and group interviews, observations and tour journals while NW3 was partially observed.

All eligible participants of the nationwide tours NW1 and NW2 were asked to complete a pre-tour questionnaire that revealed that nearly all participants came from Western and English-speaking markets, with Australia, the United Kingdom and the United States of America being well presented. Furthermore, the majority of the 33 respondents were in the 21 to 30 and 51 to 60 year age span, came from a variety of occupations, and were usually well-educated.

Overall, response rates were good, especially for the questionnaires and interviews. The pre-tour questionnaire was introduced on the first day on tour and participants were asked to complete the forms in their own time, individually and anonymously. This procedure was repeated

for the second questionnaire at the end of the tour (post-tour questionnaire). Also, structured post-tour questionnaires (email post-tour questionnaires) were sent out to the participants of both tours 12 months after the first tour and two months after the second, respectively. Overall, all 15 eligible tour participants from the first tour and all 19 eligible participants of the second tour were invited to participate. The return rate was as shown in Table 1:

Similarly, 14 tour participants of NW1 (one eligible participant declined) were individually interviewed and all eligible 19 participants were interviewed in group interviews of four, four and three participants respectively during NW2 (the change to group interviews was made to allow participants to develop each others comments).

All but one of the tour journals(from NW3) were returned and of those returned, only one (from NW2) proved unsatisfying for analysis due to its brevity, leaving 10 tour journals for analysis.

Perceptions of Authenticity and Fantasy

Questionnaires and interviews revealed that most participants did not see themselves as ‘fans’ or ‘geeks’ of the film. Instead, they came from a diversity of backgrounds and brought with them multiple expectations. Many of these expectations were based on pre-tour images from the *Lord of the Rings* films, the ‘making ofs’ that are included on the DVDs, and cast and crew interviews. Most looked forward to experiencing scenery, actual film sites and specific locations (see also Buchmann, 2006a), and also wanted a sense of fellowship. They differed markedly, however, in their motivations and expectations towards their tourism experience in New Zealand. While one stated: “That’s why my need to come to New Zealand is really not for New Zealand, at the beginning, it was to see Middle-earth and to see all the sites” (participant 304, tour NW2), for others it was the opposite: “For me I especially want to see New Zealand, *Lord of the Rings* was just an excuse to come” (participant 302, tour NW2). Such statements show the attitudes towards the ‘spectrum’ of desired experiences from that of ‘real’ New Zealand to that of the fantastic Middle-earth. Many others positioned themselves between these extremes: “What I wanted to do was New Zealand as well as the location sites... I want to experience

Table 1. Return Rate of the Questionnaires Used on the Nationwide Tour(s) NW1 and NW2

Tour	Year	Number of participants returning questionnaires
Pre-NW1 questionnaire	2004/05	15
Post-NW1 questionnaire	2004/05	14
email Post-NW1	2006	4
Pre-NW2	2005/06	19
Post-NW2	2005/06	19
email Post-NW2	2006	8

New Zealand, not only Middle-earth and that was extremely important” (participant 404, NW2).

Throughout the tour, the participants of the nationwide tours NW1 and NW2 were asked about their attitudes and hopes concerning the tour, with a particular focus on their knowledge of the films and novel, their meaning and what influenced their decision to come on this tour. All surveyed film tourists had at least started reading the original novel, and Peter Jackson’s interpretation of the *Lord of the Rings* story was widely accepted as ‘authentic’. Furthermore, all perceived the New Zealand location(s) as a fair presentation of the Middle-earth described in the novel by Tolkien (Fig. 1). Thus, despite knowing that Tolkien had developed Middle-earth in Europe, many participants emotionally perceived the New Zealand setting as authentic and worth visiting. Before the tour most tourists expected “to see and feel parts of Middle-earth. To experience the people and culture of New Zealand” (participant 28 of tour NW1), to have an “once-in-a-lifetime experience travelling around the real Middle-earth” (participant 65, tour NW2) and “to be totally captivated by the surroundings and beautiful landscape just



Figure 1. A Map of New Zealand Showing Selected *Lord of the Rings*-filming Locations. Source: [Tourism New Zealand \(2009\)](#), with *Lord of the Rings*-filming Locations inserted by the authors

as if I were on the journey [of the fellowship] myself” (participant 67, tour NW2).

Once on the tour, the actual experience was, most often, close to its anticipation. This might be partly due to the fact that many images of Middle-earth and New Zealand are similar: both are traditionally characterized by rolling farmland, lush forests, clear streams, snow-capped mountains and even deserts as well as an ‘uncomplicated’ lifestyle connected with the outdoors. The supporting role of the scenery in both the *Lord of the Rings* films and as a background for the journey cannot be underestimated and might suggest why other films might find it more difficult to offer a satisfying tourism experience. While there is some suggestion that visitors to film sites may be disappointed when they do not see exactly what was portrayed on screen (MacCannell, 1976; Preston, 2000), the opposite seems true in *Lord of the Rings* film tourism. Though one could argue that people do not expect to see exactly what they saw on the screen, most tourists are impressed by what they find. Furthermore, the power of the myths created became obvious when several tourists described visits to locations such as Edoras as “one can feel as if 8,000 years ago the *Lord of the Rings* actually happened here” (participant 01, tour NW3) and “it feels like history and we visited some archaeological site” (participant 01, tour NW3). Another tourist, too, described the distinction between film and history as purely intellectual:

Obviously one is fact, one is fiction but, in the minds of the people involved, the distinction is purely intellectual because, to some people, the Battle of Pelennor Fields might as well be as real as something like... Battle Hill, or any of the other significant European sites (participant 19, tour NW1).

The merging of Middle-earth and New Zealand was apparently common and welcomed: “I am taking this tour of New Zealand because I get to tour a real place and tour my imagination at the same time” (participant 03, tour NW1). This person clearly understood that it was possible to experience an ‘imaginary’ place through purposeful interactions with actual places and people. In such narratives of tourists’ perceptions of a destination, these tourists reveal as much about their own active participation in the experience of places as about the actual visited country (Bhattacharyya, 1997). In this case, New Zealand represents the exotic ‘other’—perhaps partly due to geographical isolation and distance from Europe. This perception is part of a continuous tradition that has influenced the reception of New Zealand films (Jones, 1999; Simmons, 1999). In modern times both the *Lord of the Rings* films and the ‘making ofs’ further promote these exotic and mythical qualities. Not incidentally, these qualities are also used for the official ‘100% Pure’ New Zealand tourism campaign in which New Zealand is portrayed as an exotic and faraway country that is green, clean, exciting and yet safe without major civil or military conflicts. Thus the image created by the *Lord of the Rings* production, its accompanying film tourism and the official New Zealand image are very similar in their promotion of mythical elements (compare also

the Air New Zealand ‘Airline to Middle-earth’-campaign and regional council advertisements for film locations, for example, the ‘Journey to Edoras’-leaflet by [Ashburton District Tourism, 2003](#)). As a consequence, most tourists have expectations that include such elements for their own holiday experience.

Most of the tourists in this study shared a common perception of New Zealand: “It is wild, it is primitive, it is remote, it is geologically young. Very ‘Middle-earth’ here. I like it” (participant 01, tour NW3). Other tourists described and interpreted the actual settings using such words as ‘spectacular’. In short, despite experiencing urban environments, consumerism, and environmental pollution, most if not all participants continued to interpret New Zealand as a green and friendly place without any significant problems: “I thought, ‘Yes, this is, indeed, Middle-earth’” (participant 58, tour NW1). Such a ‘merging’ of the country and the film represents a further challenge to questions of the authenticity of the tourist experience. However, this merging, according to many interviewees, actually is both sought out and viewed positively as it helps ‘embody’ their desired experiences of the ‘themes’ of the film in actual places. So what does this ‘merging’ mean for existential authenticity?

The Significance of Authenticity in Film Tourism

The previous sections have shown how film tourism is interlaid with myths, especially in *Lord of the Rings* tourism (compare [Buchmann, 2006b](#)). It has been indicated that ‘authenticity’ is important within film tourism though it has to be debated how ‘authentic’ a film tourism experience can be to the extent that it involves fictional places.

We argue that the *Lord of the Rings* films re-affirm the branding of New Zealand as the ‘exotic other’ that is being longed for by tourists looking for meaningful and authentic experiences ([MacCannell, 1976](#)). The fictional nature of the *Lord of the Rings* narrative becomes an aid with which to lever the acceptance of the New Zealand narrative or image. This ‘fictional authenticity’ invites the suspension of disbelief not only in the *Lord of the Rings* but also in New Zealand’s promoted brand. Further, the blending of the myths of the ‘green and unique’ New Zealand and the adventurous but also nostalgic image of Middle-earth takes place seemingly effortlessly for tourists. Similarly, Pretes (1994) discussed how Finland could successfully establish itself as the ‘original’ Santa Claus-country worth visiting.

The willingness to believe such an image, however, probably says more about the longing for immersive myths in modern time. Interestingly, these longings can be observed both in *Lord of the Rings* and *Whale Rider* tourism. Most tourists clearly project extraordinary and fantastic elements onto New Zealand and most seem willing, even eager, to immerse themselves in this mythical world: “it’s almost like we tune out reality and become engrossed in the magic. In some ways it’s rather sad having to come back to the reality” (participant 802, tour NW2). This merging of myths to achieve a form of mythical immersion (reminiscent of

anthropologist Lucien Lévy Bruhl's notion of 'participation mystique') raises an important question: How 'authentic' can a film tourism experience be given that it involves fictional places set in geographical destinations? Is there, in this case, a reality or only hyperreality?

Authenticity and Sincerity

MacCannell (1976) argues that tourists seek more authentic ways of life in places away from home; a behavior that would liken them to pilgrims who are on value-affirming journeys to distant places (Turner & Turner, 1978). The emotional connection with the *Lord of the Rings* story is central to the descriptions of the tourists' relationship. Tourists report a spiritual and meaningful relationship with *Lord of the Rings* touring even in cases where individuals know relatively little about the films or books. However, they are aware of the central themes of the novel: fellowship, adventure and sacrifice. It seems the familiarity with the overall myths is more important than an in-depth factual film or book knowledge and it is these myths that the tourists seek in the exotic setting of New Zealand. Thus the actual film tourism experience is spiritually meaningful to tourists and pilgrim-age-like in character.

This general response to the experience can be dissected into at least three distinct facets. The first two are closely related: Authentic place and embodied presence in that place. Tourists travel from one place to another. Part of that motivation is to be in the actual place where an experience can be 'had' or is understood to be potentially 'had', as constructed in tourist practice. In order to ground that experience there is an apparent need for it to be a strongly embodied experience: A sensuous encounter with place. A third feature is what might be called socially authentic experience: Those one is with (either as fellow tourists, guides or locals) must act in a consistent way with, and acknowledge, the authentic valuation of the experience. With all of these in place an existentially authentic experience can be achieved. At its most refined this is felt as a spiritual experience.

Couldry (1998) notes how important the physical presence of the film tourists is for the experience of the *Coronation Street* set. Similarly, in *Lord of the Rings* tourism the importance of physical presence is described as crucial: "It's a matter of just standing in the place where the action happened. You stand there, you can kind of feel the vibrations or something. It really happened there. It just makes it so much more real" (participant 402, tour NW2). These statements show the importance of the physical element within the film tourism experience, ultimately creating an embodied spiritual experience. Most tourists speak about the significance of being able to spend time on the location and to develop a sense of place. This is further strengthened by tourists' comments about their idea of a perfect tour: many wish for even more physical activities and exposure. Many tourists deem it important to "actually walk out and be in the spot" (participant 48, tour NW1). Yet, many tourists are subsequently surprised to find themselves in New Zealand.

Embodiment turns out to be a central aspect of the overall experience and again, this likens film tourists to pilgrims. As Barsalou, Barbey, Simmons, and Santos (2005) point out, embodied knowledge is central to the various aspects of the religious experience. The element of embodiment also helps counteract feelings of surreality that many tourists reported when arriving, or during time, at a previously ‘mentally’ experienced but not visited place. One tourist found it hard to believe she had finally made it to the geographical location and even after having visited several locations still describes the experience as “kind of surreal” (participant 61, tour NW1). The same tourist added: “I’m really over the moon that we’ve seen these amazing places, but... I can’t quite explain... it hasn’t quite hit me that we’ve been to these magical places” (participant 61, tour NW1). This is somewhat understandable as each location actually connects two places: the cinematic portrait and the geographical place. Consequently the physical presence became very important in negotiating the two places. Only then could the ‘aura’ of the place be felt and the experience authenticated.

Aden, Rahoi, and Beck (1995) also emphasize the importance of physical interaction with a site and report a sense of awe from their tourists in reaction to the main location of the film *Field of Dreams*. Even adverse weather conditions contribute further authenticity. The significance of being physically exposed to the elements is considerable: “Walking back [from Mordor] through the fog, wind and stinging rain in my face was exhilarating. This is so different from any tour I’ve ever been on. This tour is so ‘physical’, I’m feeling this country [New Zealand] not just seeing” (participant 12, tour NW1). This statement describes the feelings of ‘being alive’ and shows the high value the tourist puts on this experience. It also shows that film tourists, like pilgrims, welcome physical exercise and even discomfort as a further validation of their experience as authentic.

The wish and need to be part of a larger community is a further parallel between (organized) film tourists and pilgrims (Turner & Turner, 1978). Many tourists hope that others will share their understanding and love of the stories—and their search. The variety of shared physical activities and meal times provides opportunities not only to interact and bond with each other but also to continually reconstruct the reality and significance of the experiences on tour. Aden et al. (1995) report a similar finding. In both cases (*Field of Dreams* and *Lord of the Rings*) the tourists come as strangers who share a common interest and search. This is similar to Squire’s (1994) findings that tourists seem to enjoy communicating and presumably re-evaluating their personal attitudes and values during their participation in a temporary community. At times the presence and form of the group seems to make it easier to remain immersed in the experience: “the group is such a close group, we kind of entertain each other and we continue the magic of the tour, even though we’re not on an actual activity tour” (participant 54, tour NW1).

Consequently, most tourists also want a personal bond with their leader, guide(s) and even driver. They are disappointed when they as-

sume the guide(s) is only doing the job as a routine task as they wish for an enthusiastic and even immersed guide: “you’ve got to have guides who just love the theme, love the topic, love the film or whatever it is, as much as the people who are on the tour. I think that’s really important” (participant 62, tour NW1). This is important because many, if not the majority, of film tourists on this organized tour saw themselves as being on a spiritually meaningful journey, and thus wanted a leader who would show commitment to this cause. Most tourists wished to see enthusiasm and even passion for the subject in their leader and guide(s), someone who is personally touched by the subject and willing to not only ‘join the fellowship’ but also to lead it. This allows many to feel a deeper connection to the theme of the journey. Displaying enthusiasm and immersion is, or becomes, more important for the tourists than factual knowledge about the films; and even lack of book and film knowledge does not necessarily ruin the experience (as, for example, the South Island driver who was held in high regard by the tourists despite a lack of *Lord of the Rings*-related knowledge) (also compare to Hughes, 1991). At the same time, so-called “false enthusiasm” (participant 59, tour NW1) is strongly condemned; the tourists prefer to encounter fellow fans and not routine guides: “I wasn’t expecting [it] but it makes such a difference when the guides are a fan of the films as well and if they’re not, there’s something that comes through that tells you” (participant 59, tour NW1).

These statements demonstrate that the (film) tourism experience not only depends on the knowledge and skills of the guide, as often stated in the general tourism literature (Schmidt, 1979; compare also Grinder & McCoy, 1985; Pastorelli, 2003), but also on more elusive qualities of being consistent with the depth of experience tourists seek (this might be true for all guided tours, though no doubt in context dependent ways). The experience is especially influenced by an interactive relationship between the tourists and the guide(s). In both cases, the relationships among the tourists and their relationship to their guide(s), the concept of ‘sincerity’ is important. It takes place when there are genuine encounters between tourists and guides and thus complements the concepts of ‘objective’ and ‘constructed’ authenticity; “rather than seeing value as the emanation of an ‘authentic object’, the moment of interaction may become the site in which value is generated” (Taylor, 2001, p. 9). It is particularly this authenticity of relationships that matter to film tourists, both within the community of fellow travelers and in interaction with their tour leader and guides. The tour is a collective creation and, in that purposeful and creative process, the authenticity of the experience is judged.

CONCLUSION

As noted in the introduction, the discussion had the objective of synthesizing previous approaches to authenticity, including ‘hyperreality’

and ‘simulacra’, within the context of a seemingly ‘perfect’ example of multilayered simulation and artifice, and to extend the conceptual framework referred to as ‘theoplicity’ to propose a suitable framework for the study of film tourism.

The intriguing questions that arise from this study orbit around the complex way in which film tourists appear to appreciate the ‘authentic’ in a world that is so fully simulated and which trades directly on the blurring of fantasy and reality. As discussed in the introduction, Eco’s (1983) ‘hyperreality’ and Baudrillard’s (1983) ‘simulacra’ seem tailor-made for film tourism. The worlds one sees on the big screen are such simulacra: places that never existed but seem to have been based on real locations. In fact, real and hyperreal experiences were at times merged in the narratives of tourists who spoke about the history and mythology of Middle-earth and New Zealand. Even more poignantly, one tourist saw the Middle-earth mythology as complementary to New Zealand in the same way that the cultural heritage of Greece is to modern Greece.

Overall, anecdotal evidence seems to suggest that reality and hyperreality can evoke the same emotions. Couldry’s (1998) study of the *Coronation Street* set shows how the simulation of a street became its own reality through its signification as a film set: the fictional setting is considered authentic. Like the setting of Edoras/Mount Sunday, the location is seen as the “‘real place’ of filming, not a mere ‘mock-up’” (Couldry, 1998, p. 97). Similarly, Pretes (1995) described how a tourism industry established itself around the simulacrum of Santa Claus in Finland, where, too, tourists have been convinced that they are visiting the ‘original’ Santa Claus country. But how can fictional elements and places become so real? The answer might partly lie in the medium of film itself, in the way films are produced and film images perceived. The very production of film requires considerable organization and results in a highly de-fragmented product. All these facts question the very use of the term ‘authenticity’ in connection with film. It is no doubt for these reasons that many authors keep referring to ‘hyperreality’ and ‘simulacra’ in connection with film tourism research (compare, for example, Beeton, 2005; Carl, Kindon, & Smith, 2007; Couldry, 1998; Graml, 2004; Mazierska & Walton, 2006; Pretes, 1995; Schofield, 1996; Torchin, 2003; Tzanelli, 2004). Yet, authenticity remains relevant for film tourism in one important aspect: Tourists themselves attribute high value to their judgments of authenticity. These research findings strengthen the argument that film tourists seek authentic experiences and that any such authentic experiences depend on place as well as upon the wider processes in which any interpretations of the experience take place.

Such ‘processes’ amount to something rather more than, for example, individual tourists’ ‘expectations’ or ‘attitudes’. They are commitments, often, but not always, of a deep nature. In particular, they are personal commitments to internalized yet broadly operating social processes, values and understandings that have been imbibed through personal experiences, sometimes stretching over a person’s entire life.

Such processes can facilitate mythological functions which—in properly structured physical settings, places and social situations—deliver to the tourist an experience of considerable significance and particular value. The tourist experience involves place both in its ‘real’ form, in this case New Zealand, and in its hyper-real form, Middle Earth which is constructed through a literary mythology in books and film. The tourist experience, however, is also constructed through action. What tourists do is an integral part of their construction of reality and authenticity. In the case of *Lord of the Rings* tourists this is illustrated in the sense of belonging that is created within the group. The group creates a fellowship in which the mythology of the story can be realized through activities that occur at places that have become significant as a consequence of the films. It is through this process that New Zealand becomes Middle Earth. The destination is transformed from being the place where the filming took place to become the place that was seen on the screen.

More specifically, this research has illustrated the complexity of the concept of authenticity in relation to film tourism. It has built upon the notions of existential authenticity presented by Wang (1999) and Kim and Jamal (2007) to the extent that it places existential authenticity within an objectively authentic setting even though this setting (New Zealand) could be described as, itself, a concoction of simulacra. With *Lord of the Rings* tourism a place has been altered for a film which has created a sign for a book, which itself has been used to create signs of a past that is threatened by change for the worst. Nothing is real except what the tourists ‘believe’ (or enact). Yet, tourists have to have a real place in which they can develop, nurture and elaborate their understandings and beliefs. It seemed that for most of our film tourists it was the merging of both reality and myths that made for the most fulfilling, and authentic, experience: “for me to be able to walk onto those fields is magical because I keep turning around looking for Gandalf or Frodo or somebody. And yet at the same time I’m able to bend down and touch the grass” (participant 803, tour NW2). This statement highlights the importance of being physically on location where reality and film can finally be merged. Existential authenticity still has to submit to judgments of ‘object’ authenticity: ‘This IS the spot where that scene was filmed’. In this way, and as the philosopher Wittgenstein famously put it, from the perspective of our film tourists such acts validate the hope that—in the best sense of the phrase—‘The world is *my* world’. That world is not experienced as some personal, or even social, concoction but as the *real* world. For brief moments, and when the right ingredients colude, the gap between self and world can close.

Whilst these tourists have come to New Zealand to visit an imaginary place populated by imaginary people they do this in what Pretes (1995) argues is a postmodern way: “The marker confers upon the sight an importance that makes it an object of the tourist gaze” (Pretes, 1995, p. 12). This marker may be accepted as fake (as in the case of the extra who spoke to the tourists in a costume he had made himself rather than in the costume he wore in the film). However, with

Lord of the Rings tourism, the marker also points to an ethos that is transmitted from the story (whether in book or film form). This is where existential authenticity comes to the fore. Existential authenticity relies upon judgments of place as the ‘real’ appropriate places and of experiences cashed out in embodied sensations. The “existential state of Being activated by certain tourist activities” (Wang, 1999, p. 359) therefore hinges on a range of ‘objects’ taken as authentic by the tourist and upon a physically embodied and socially supported encounter with place. It is the use made of this range of authenticating resources by tourists that leads them to understand their experiences as more or less ‘authentic’. For existential authenticity to be accepted it must be grounded in some form of objective authenticity but the object can be mired in a wide range of artifice. The commodification of the intangible aspects of the book allow for the consumption of both objectively and existentially authentic products. In some senses this supports Belhassen et al.’s (2008, p. 684) argument that tourists’ “experiences of existential authenticity are the result of socially constructed understandings about the places they are touring and the actions they are undertaking in those places, combined with their own direct, empirical encounters”. However, from the point of view of the tourists their ‘socially constructed understandings’ and their ‘direct, empirical encounters’ have merged: The sensation of the touched grass is an empirical encounter with both New Zealand and Middle-Earth.

Beyond embodied encounters with place, these tourists’ judgments of authenticity are also inseparable from their concerns with fellowship and sincerity. The study shows that tourists wanted ‘passion’ from the people who were involved in the tour. It is here that sincerity plays a part: The value of the sought experience must matter to all involved. Just as the grass in physical places is ‘touched’ to validate the experience, so too members of the social group must, through social contact, validate the experience for each other.

The findings also suggest that at least the most dedicated film tourists are indeed similar to pilgrims as Riley and Van Doren (1992) and Couldry (1998) suggest. Both are on a centrally meaningful journey to often distant places. Both follow scripted guidelines while also creating their own experience. Both experience benefits: comforting emotions; a perceived offering of strength, empowerment and control; social support and a sense of belonging. Overall, most of our film tourists were ‘followers’ very much like pilgrims: people were willing to ‘follow in the footsteps’ to visit places that had attained an *aura* in their own eyes, authenticated by cast and crew comments. Film tourists actively create their journey by showing commitment, a willingness to endure hardship and build a community (fellowship) with other participants.

A further theoretical innovation arising from this study is that the framework suggested by Belhassen et al. (2008) can be usefully extended beyond religious tourism. It is clearly valid for other forms of tourism. The ‘theoplacity’ framework, however, undervalues the significant role of embodiment. In this case, film tourists are most

moved by a multi-sensory encounter with geographical places, in ways not dissimilar to the embodied ‘performances’ of adventure tourists. Thus we propose the extension of the ‘theoplicity’ framework not only to a ‘non-religious’ (albeit ‘spiritual’) kinds of tourism (film tourism) but also to incorporate embodied experience of places and the social solidarity of common goals (the fellowship aspect of much tourism).

In final conclusion, tourists’ experiences of authenticity are often complex productions of personal history and knowledge, social processes, embodiment and place. Complex production of the experience of authenticity does not, however, make it any the less authentic. **A**

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